



tion at Rs 14,000. Similarly, companies such as Samsung and Canon have models ranging from Rs 14,500 upwards. HP and Lexmark also have entry level models costing around Rs 15,500 and above.

Today, the competition is fiercer in the inkjet market than in the niche laser printer segment, because a majority of prospective buyers—home and small-office users—don't find a laser printer economically viable. Major brands that have a strong presence in the inkjet segment are HP, Epson, Canon and Lexmark. HP has been around for a quite a while, and has used this advantage to build up a good reputation when it comes to inkjet printers. Lexmark offers the

cheapest solution with its Z13 inkjet printer. HP is not left behind and offers the cute little 3325. Similar models are also offered by Epson and Canon.

In the mid-range inkjet segment, Epson has some decent offers that offer excellent performance at a very good price, like the C61sx. Among high-end inkjets, Canon, Epson and HP have a plethora of models to choose from, such as the Canon S530D, Epson stylus 915 and the HP 7550. These photo printers are capable of printing photos directly from a digital camera, have good colour management controls and are provided with a small LCD for direct control.

Low-end inkjet printers start at Rs 3,000 and can go up to Rs 6,000, whereas mid-range inkjet printers are priced between Rs 7,000 and 16,000. High-end printers retail for anything over Rs 18,000.



Buying Tips for Inkjet Printers

■ Choose your printer based on the kind of print quality you require. In general, inkjet printers offer excellent quality as far as images and graphics are concerned, while laser printers offer the best text printouts.

■ If you are planning to buy an inkjet printer, make sure you check the page per minute (ppm) speed, since the manufacturer-rated speed is always relative to the printer's fastest print mode, and not the normal or best quality mode which are used more often.

■ If you intend to share the printer over a network, check the amount of buffer memory—the more the better.

■ If you are buying the printer for photo printouts, always take a test print to ensure you get the required quality. Also check if you need to purchase a separate ink cartridge for photo quality printouts.

■ Check for the type of interface supported by your PC. Most computers today have USB ports, so buy a printer with a USB interface since it offers higher speed of data transfer.

■ Consider the total cost of ownership and not just the purchase price. Depending on how many pages you print, even a small difference of a rupee will save you a sizeable amount of cash over the lifetime of the printer.

■ Check whether the printer supports additional features like ink status determination via software, so you can be sure when to

change the cartridge.

■ Check the manufacturer's Web site for the type of support offered—do they offer regular software updates, patches for new operating systems, and so on.

■ Check the space requirements of the printer so that it fits comfortably on your desk.

Buying Tips for Laser Printers

■ A carry-in warranty is definitely a big pain as far as bulky items like laser printers are concerned. The warranty should be comprehensive and on-site.

■ The greater the warranty period, the better. It indicates that the manufacturer has greater faith in the product.

■ Faster and higher quality printers are a lot costlier than slower ones. If you're in no hurry to take your printouts, or don't need excellent quality, set your sights a little lower. You'll end up saving much money that way.

■ With costly peripherals such as laser printers, it breaks your heart when they crash or malfunction. Add lousy customer service you are ready to throw the said peripheral out of the window. Ask people who've already bought printers about their experiences with the customer-support staff. It might take some effort, but is



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